2. Grass land vegetation

Grassland refer to the vegetation community predominated by graminoids (i.e. grass and grass like plants). These are found in the altitude ranging from 150 to 2000 m and above mean sea level. The major plant families of the plants are Poaceae, Cyperaceae, Fabaceae , Gentianaceae and Asteraceae are common in this type of vegetation. The grass land not only comprises plants but also serves as habitats to a variety of micro and macro fauna. Based on the range of altitude, grasslands are categorized into: low altitude grasslands and high altitude grasslands.

DO YOU KNOW?

Grasslands created and maintained by human are called anthropogenic grasslands.

a. Low altitude grasslands

This type of grasslands are found at an altitude upto 1000 m. The common plant species are *Halopyrum,* Wild *Saccharum, Arundinella, Heteropogon* and *Chrysopogon.* These types of grasslands are spread over coastal areas, riverline and alluvial areas of Deccan plateau, Chota Nagpur plateau, Gangetic, Brahmaputra valley and Eastern Ghats.

In Tamil Nadu, these are found in the Eastern Ghats .These are scattered and intermixed with local forests. They are exposed to considerable biotic interference. Fire is common during dry months.

b. Higher altitude grasslands

This type of grasslands are found in altitude above 1000 m.The common plants species are *Chrysopogon, Arundinella, Andropogon, Heteropogon, Cymbopogon, Imperata, Festuca,* and *Agrostis.*. It is spread over the southern slopes of Himalayas, sub-Himalayan ranges, Nagaland, Himachal Pradesh and Western ghats.



Figure 7.24: Higher altitude grassland

In Tamil Nadu ,these grasslands are found in higher regions of western ghats and are found between the sholas forest patches that occur in the depressions and furrows created by water courses flowing in these rolling downs are called as **rolling grassland** and also called **shola grassland**. It shows different types of vegetation like grasses, herbs, few shrubs and stunted trees.

DO YOU KNOW?

Existence of two climax communities under the influence of same climatic conditions are found in higher mountain hill tops, above 7000 feet MSL (Mean sea level) of Nilgiris. Example: Sholas and grasslands.

3. Riparian Vegetation

This type of vegetation is located along streams and rivers. The most common species are, *Terminalia, Diospyros,Salix,Ficus* and grasses. They are found on the banks of Godavari, Krishna, Ganga, Brahmaputria, Narmadha Yamuna and riverbeds of Cauvery and Thamirabharani in Tamil Nadu.

Activity

Visit nearby forest and water bodies, observe the species found, describe and then identify the various types of vegetation

4. Aquatic And Semi-Aquatic Vegetation

This type of vegetation is found in lakes, ponds, puddles and marshy places. The common plant species are *Nelumbo, Nymphaea, Bacopa, Typha, Pandanus, Cyperus, Aeschynomene, Hydrilla, Aponogeton* and *Potomogeton*. It is found in various parts of Tamil Nadu.

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